

SCHOOLWELL

EMOTION CARDS WITH EXERCISES

UNDERSTAND - NAME - REACT



We support emotional well-being at school



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SchoolWell – Emotion Cards with Exercises

Teachers' Guide

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INTRODUCTION

School is not only a place for acquiring knowledge and developing skills. It is also a space where children and young people experience a variety of emotions every day, build relationships, face challenges, and learn to recognize their own needs. The mental and emotional well-being of students and teachers is an important element in creating a safe, supportive, and welcoming school environment.

Teachers' guide: SchoolWell – emotion cards with exercises was created as part of the Erasmus+ project "SchoolWell – Promoting well-being at school" (2025-1-PL01-KA210-SCH-000356998).

The kit was created to support the well-being of students and teachers and to develop competences related to recognizing and expressing emotions, building relationships, mindfulness, coping with stress, self-care and personal development.

The cards are a simple and flexible tool that can be used during lessons, homeroom hours, team-building activities, workshops, individual meetings, and group work. Their purpose is not to provide ready-made answers, but to create a space for conversation, reflection, and mutual listening.

What's included in the kit?

Navy Blue Cards – 22 cards

They contain illustrations depicting emotions, situations, relationships, and metaphorical scenes. The images can be a starting point for conversation, reflection, storytelling, or naming one's own experiences.

Green cards – 18 cards

They contain guiding questions that facilitate conversations about emotions, needs, relationships and experiences.

The cards can be freely combined to create a variety of exercises tailored to the age of participants, group size, lesson objectives and the current needs of students and teachers.

Who can use the cards?

The kit has been prepared primarily for people working with children and young people, in particular:

- teachers,
- educators,
- educators,
- psychologists,
- specialists working with children and young people.

The cards can also be used in teamwork among teachers and during activities supporting the well-being of the entire school community.

How to use the guide?

The guide is practical in nature, offering suggested exercises and activities that can be carried out using the cards in individual and group sessions. It also includes tips on how to conduct a conversation, ask questions, and create an atmosphere that fosters openness and safety.

The proposed activities relate to, among others, areas such as:

- recognizing and naming emotions,
- expressing emotions and needs,
- self-awareness and self-reflection,
- relationships and communication,
- mindfulness and concentration,
- coping with stress.

Each exercise can be modified and adapted to a specific group. There's no single correct way to use the cards—their strength lies in the ability to creatively apply them to any situation.

A space for conversation, not judgment

When working with the cards, it's especially important to create an atmosphere of acceptance, respect, and voluntariness. Participants should be able to share their reflections, but they shouldn't be forced to reveal personal experiences or emotions. It's worth remembering that the same illustration can evoke completely different associations in different people. Therefore, there is no single

"correct" interpretation of the card. It is this diversity of perspectives that can become the beginning of a valuable conversation.

The role of the teacher or facilitator is primarily to guide participants through the reflection process, ask questions, and listen carefully. The cards are not intended to diagnose emotional states or replace professional psychological support. They are an educational and developmental tool that helps build a culture of conversation about well-being in the school.

Together for well-being at school

SchoolWell encourages us to consider well-being as an important part of everyday school life. A brief conversation about emotions, a moment of mindfulness, reflection on our own needs, or a shared exploration of ways to manage stress can become small steps toward greater self-awareness, better relationships, and a more supportive school atmosphere.

We hope that SchoolWell cards will be a practical and inspiring tool that will help you introduce conversations about emotions and wellbeing into your everyday work with students – in a way that is natural, engaging and tailored to their needs.

THE ROLE OF THE TEACHER

The person leading the class plays primarily the role of a moderator and guide who helps students recognize, name and express emotions and develop the ability to understand the emotions of others.

The tasks of the instructor include:

- Card Selection – Choose cards appropriate to the age, abilities and current needs of your students.
- Active listening – listen carefully to what students say, do not judge their answers and leave room for different interpretations.
- Creating a safe atmosphere – remind students that every emotion is valid and that they do not have to share their personal experiences.
- Supporting collaboration – organize individual, pair and group work, encouraging students to listen to each other.
- Developing reflection – ask questions that help students think about the causes of emotions, their symptoms, and ways to cope with them.
- Observing students – pay attention to their reactions, engagement, and difficulties in recognizing and expressing emotions.
- Summary of the lesson – at the end, help students organize their most important conclusions and highlight what they learned during the lesson.

WHAT IS WORTH REMEMBERING?

 **At the beginning, it is worth telling the students/participants:**

- “There are no right or wrong answers.”
- “Anyone can say as much as they want.”
- “You can talk about the picture, not about yourself.”

 **While working:**

- thank them for comments,
- let students interpret the pictures in their own way,
- don't force anyone to answer,
- maintain a peaceful atmosphere.

 **What to avoid?**

- evaluating responses,
- interpreting students,
- asking too personal questions,
- dragging out exercises.

Part I

Short exercises to start the class (3–7 minutes)

Exercise 1 – Emotion Thermometer

 **Form:** Whole class

 **Time:** 3–5 minutes

 **Goal:** Quickly check the mood of the group, develop self-awareness.

 **Preparation:** Place 4–5 dark blue cards representing different emotions on the board or spread out on the floor.

 **Instructions:**

- Ask students, "Look at these images for a moment. Which one best fits your mood right now?"
- Students can point to a selected card, stand next to it, or write the card number on a sticky note.
- Ask 2–3 volunteer students: "What word best describes this card?"

 **Variants:**

 **Option 1 – Morning and afternoon:** Do the exercise at the beginning and end of the day to observe changes in your mood.

 **Option 2 – Finger Evaluation:** Students point to the selected card and show 1 to 5 fingers, indicating the intensity of their mood.

Exercise 2 – Instant Association

 **Form:** Circle work

 **Time:** 5 minutes

 **Goal:** Naming emotions, spontaneous associations and group activation.

 **Preparation:** Place a deck of navy blue cards face down in the center of the circle.

 **Instructions:**

- Turn over one navy blue card so everyone can see it.
- Students take turns, clockwise, saying one word that comes to mind.
- Previously given words cannot be repeated; if necessary, the student can skip their turn.
- Repeat the exercise with 2–3 cards.

 **Variants:**

 **Option 1 – Sound Effect:** Students make a sound or sigh that matches the situation or emotion depicted on the card.

 **Option 2 – Color Association:** Students name a color that they associate with the emotion shown on the card.

Exercise 3 – Select and Replace

 **Form:** Physical activity / pair work

 **Time:** 5–7 minutes

 **Goal:** Building relationships with peers, short conversations and casual interaction.

 **Preparation:** Give each student one navy blue card.

 **Instructions:**

- Students move around the room.
- When the teacher claps or says STOP, students pair up with the person closest to them.
- Each person says in one sentence what emotion they see on their card and what caught their attention.
- The students then swap cards and begin moving again.
- Repeat the exercise for 2–3 rounds.

 **Variants:**

Option 1 – Swap Questions: Instead of using navy blue cards, give half the class green cards. Those with green cards pair up with those with blue cards and ask them the questions from the green cards.

Exercise 4 – Where am I today?

 **Form:** Whole group / individual reflection

 **Time:** 3–5 minutes

 **Goal:** Recognizing your own well-being, developing emotional self-awareness and starting classes calmly.

 **Preparation:** Place several navy blue cards in different places around the room.

 **Instructions:**

- Lay out 5–6 navy blue cards and ask students to look at all the pictures for a moment.
- Say: “Choose the card that best represents how you feel today or what you bring to class.”
- Students approach the selected card.
- Those interested can say one sentence: “I chose this card because...”
- Emphasize that there are no right or wrong choices and everyone can decide whether they want to share their reflections.

 **Variants:**

 **Option 1 – One Word:** Each participant says only one word describing their current mood.

 **Option 2 – Without speaking:** Students simply choose a card without having to explain their choice.

Part II

Group work and physical activity (10–15 minutes)

Exercise 5 – Discovering emotions

 **Form:** Whole class / group work

 **Time:** 10–15 minutes

 **Goal:** Developing vocabulary related to emotions and associative thinking.

 **Preparation:** Prepare navy blue and green cards.

Instructions:

- Each student draws one navy blue card.
- Ask students to look at the illustration for a few seconds and think, “What does this card tell me today?”
- Students then pair up and spend about a minute sharing their first thought or association.
- Each pair draws one green card and together answers the question on it.
- Finally, ask, “Did the answer to the question change the way you look at the card you chose?”

Variants:

 **Option 1 – My Password:** After finishing, students choose one word they would like to take with them to today's class.

 **Option 2 – Common Card:** The pair chooses one navy blue card and then together creates a short slogan or sentence that best expresses its meaning.

Exercise 6 – Emotion Gallery

 **Form:** Whole class/group

 **Time:** About 15 minutes

 **Goal:** Activating the group, sharing opinions and recognizing emotions and their own associations with illustrations.

 **Preparation:** Spread the navy blue cards out in different places around the room, leaving enough space to move freely.

 **Instructions:**

- Say: "Walk around the room, look at the illustrations, and stand next to the card that catches your eye the most."
- Once students have chosen their cards, ask, "What caught your eye?" "Why did you choose this particular illustration?"
- Students talk briefly in pairs, small groups or together as a class.

 **Variants:**

 **Option 1 – Silent Gallery:** Students silently write down their associations or impressions on sticky notes and place them next to the selected cards.

Option 2 – Question Walk: Attach a green card to each illustration. Students move between the cards and discuss the questions on them.

Exercise 7 – Without words

 **Form:** Whole group

 **Time:** 10–15 minutes

 **Goal:** Recognizing and expressing emotions through facial expressions, gestures and movement, and activating the group.

 **Preparation:** Prepare the navy blue cards and choose a place where one student can stand facing the group.

Instructions:

- One student draws a navy blue card and does not show it to the others.
- The student looks at the illustration and imitates the emotion or situation depicted in it, using facial expressions, gestures and movement.
- The other students observe and try to guess what emotion or situation is on the card.
- The first person to guess correctly may become the next participant.
- Repeat the game with a few more cards.

Variants:

 **Variant – Teams:** Divide the class into two teams. The first team to guess the emotion receives a point.

Part III

Pairwork, empathy and perspective-taking (10–15 minutes)

Exercise 8 – The Hero's Voice

 Form: Pair work  Time: 10 minutes

 Goal: Developing empathy, the ability to express thoughts and feelings and take the perspective of another person.

 Preparation: Navy blue cards. Students sit in pairs or in a circle.

Instructions:

- Students choose one character from the illustration.
- Say: "Imagine you are this character. Complete the following sentences: "I am the character on this card, and I would like to say that..."
- "Right now I feel..." "I need..."
- If students are having difficulty, encourage them with additional questions: "What would this character like to hear?"

Variants:

 Option 1 – Interview with a Character: One student takes on the role of a character and the other person acts as a reporter and asks questions such as "What happened?" and "Who can help you?"

 Option 2 – Hero Letter: The student writes a short, 3-sentence message from the perspective of a chosen character.

 Option 3 – What happens next?: Students imagine what will happen to the hero 5 minutes later and tell the rest of his story.

Exercise 9 – Emotion Detective

 **Form:** Work in pairs

 **Time:** 10–15 minutes

 **Goal:** Developing active listening, reading non-verbal signals and taking the other person's perspective.

 **Preparation:** Each pair receives 3 navy blue cards placed face down.

 **Instructions:**

- Student A looks at one card without showing it to student B.
- Student A uses only body posture and facial expressions to convey the emotion or meaning of the card.
- Student B tries to guess the emotion or situation depicted on the card.
- Student A shows the card to check the answer.
- The students then switch roles and continue playing with the remaining cards.

 **Variants:**

 **Variant – Green Card Hint:** Student A draws a green card and answers the question on it. The answer serves as a hint for student B.

Exercise 10 – Empathy Bridge

 **Form:** Work in pairs

 **Time:** 10–15 minutes

 **Goal:** Showing understanding in difficult situations and developing supportive communication.

 **Preparation:** Each player chooses 1 navy blue card representing a difficult emotion (anger, despair, sadness, etc.).

 **Instructions:**

- Students briefly think about what would make the character feel heard and understood.
- The couple writes a short, supportive message to the character depicted on the card.

 **Variant** – Reversing the Situation: Students also choose a card representing a solution to a problem, peace, or a situation that improves well-being and consider what actions might help to move from one state to the other.

Part IV

**Small group collaboration and
storytelling (15–20 minutes)**

Exercise 11 – Hero's Story

 **Format:** Pair work/small group work  **Time:** 15–20 min

 **Goal:** Developing storytelling skills, empathy, and group cooperation and communication.

 **Preparation:** Each group receives 1 navy card.

Instructions:

- Say: "Your task is to create a story about the character in this illustration."
- The groups reflect together on the following questions:
- Who is this character and what could have happened?
- What do you feel and what do you need right now?
- What will happen next?
- Each group briefly presents their story to the class.

Variants:

 **Option 1 – Heroes' Dialogue:** Draw two navy blue cards and write a conversation between the characters depicted on them.

 **Option 2 – Mini scene:** Act out a short, approximately 30-second improvised scene inspired by the illustration.

 **Option 3 – Next Chapter:** Draw or write a continuation of the story – a scene that could happen later.

Exercise 12 – Common Position

 **Format:** Work in small groups (3–5 people)  **Time:** 20 min

 **Goal:** Developing discussion skills, active listening and taking into account different perspectives.

 **Preparation:** Each group receives 1 navy blue card, 2–3 green cards and a sheet of paper.

Instructions:

- Say, "Your task is to find answers to these questions together. Make sure everyone has the opportunity to speak."
- Students take turns answering the questions. The group writes down their collective conclusions and the various ideas and opinions that emerged during the conversation.
- Each group presents its conclusions to the whole class.
- Finally, ask:
 - "Was it difficult to reach an agreement?"
 - "Did anyone's point of view change during the discussion?"

Variants:

 **Option 1 – Poster:** Write down the group's conclusions on a poster, using keywords and symbols.

 **Option 2 – Mind Map:** Create a map of associations, the starting point of which will be the illustration in the middle.

 **Option 3 – Make up your own question:** Make up a new question for the chosen card and ask it to another group.

Exercise 13 – Emotion Comic

 **Format:** Work in small groups (3–4 people)

 **Time:** 15–20 minutes

 **Goal:** Developing cause-and-effect thinking, understanding the sequence of events and the relationship between situations and emotions.

 **Preparation:** Each group draws 3 navy blue cards.

 **Instructions:**

- Groups place 3 cards next to each other
- They then create a story explaining what caused the change from the situation depicted on card 1 to the situation on card 3.
- Each group presents their three-stage story to the class.

 **Variants:**

 **Option 1 – The Missing Middle:** The teacher shows the group card 1 and card 3. Students invent and write down or draw a missing event that could have led from the first situation to the second.

Option 2 – The Grand Class Chain: Each group adds one card to the class story they're creating together. Additional cards are added to the board, creating an increasingly longer story.

Activity 14 – Classroom Support Network

 **Form:** Work in groups of 4–5 people

 **Time:** 15–20 minutes

 **Goal:** Recognizing sources of support, strengthening peer solidarity and developing awareness of the school climate.

 **Preparation:** Place 2–3 dark blue cards representing difficult situations in the center of a large sheet of paper.

 **Instructions:**

- Groups think about ways to get support, such as “What helps you feel safe?”
- Around the cards, students write down specific people, places, and ways of support they can use at school, e.g., a counselor or school psychologist, friends, a quiet place, deep breathing.
- Students then draw lines connecting specific support methods to challenging situations. The lines can represent “ropes” that create a visual network of safety and support.

 **Variants:**

 **Option 1 – Test-time kit:** Focus on ways to deal with test anxiety and study-related stress.

Part V

**Self-regulation, stress management, and
reflection (10–25 minutes)**

Exercise 15 – Reducing Stress

 **Format:** Individual or pair work  **Time:** 15–20 min

 **Goal:** Recognizing sources of tension, developing emotion regulation skills and strengthening the sense of agency.

 **Preparation:** Spread the navy blue cards in the center of the table.

Instructions:

- Say: “Find a card that represents stress, tension, or difficult emotions.”
- Then say, “Now choose a card that represents peace, security, or relief.”
- Ask: “What specific action can help someone move from the first state to the second?”
- Students write down their ideas, discuss them in pairs, or create an individual action plan.

Variants:

 Option 1 – Three steps: Students answer the questions: “What causes me stress?”, “What can I do before the stress gets worse?”, “What helps me calm down?”

 Option 2 – The Path to Calm: Students draw a line connecting both cards and write down the next steps along it that might help them deal with a difficult situation.

 Option 3 – Support Sentence: Students complete the sentence: “It helps me when...”

Exercise 16 – My Emotion Card

 **Form:** Individual creative work  **Time:** About 25 minutes

 **Goal:** Creative self-expression, better understanding and integrating one's own emotions, and strengthening one's sense of agency.

 **Preparation:** Sheets of paper, markers, crayons, scissors and materials for making a collage.

Instructions:

- Say: “Create your own emotion card that represents a chosen feeling, a personal strength, or how you are feeling right now.”
- Students give their cards a title. They can also choose one question from the green card and answer it in relation to their work.
- The finished cards can be voluntarily presented on the class board or created into a shared gallery.

Variants:

 **Option 1 – My Day:** Illustrate the course of a typical day at school, showing its different moments and the emotions that accompany them.

 **Option 2 – My Superpower:** Present your inner strength, skill or resource that helps you cope with difficulties.

 **Option 3 – Collage:** Create an emotion card using the collage technique, using images and fragments from unnecessary magazines.

Part VI

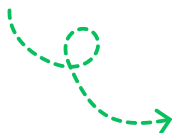
Exercises with the SchoolWell app

The SchoolWell card set is complemented by the SchoolWell app, which provides an additional, interactive tool to support student and teacher well-being. The app allows for the use of cards in digital spaces and facilitates regular engagement with topics related to emotions, relationships, mindfulness, and mental health.

The cards and app can be used independently or combined, depending on the group's needs and the purpose of the session. The app can complement the work with the cards, inspire conversation, reflection, and short exercises, and provide a way to continue well-being activities outside of class.

Link and QR code for the SchoolWell app:

<https://insolitus-create.github.io/SchoolWell/pl/>



Exercise 17 – What emotion is this?

 **Form of work:** whole class  **Time:** 5 minutes

 Application usage: multimedia board / projector

Instructions:

Display the chosen emotion card in the SchoolWell app. Ask students to look carefully at the illustration.

Ask:

- "What do you think the person depicted on the card is feeling?"
- "How can we recognize this emotion?"
- "What on her face or in her posture indicates this emotion?"

 **Tip:** Emphasize that the same illustration can be interpreted differently.

Exercise 18 – Emotional Mirror

 **Form of work:** work in pairs  **Time:** 5 minutes

Application use: tablet / multimedia board

Instructions:

- Display a card representing a chosen emotion. Divide students into pairs.

- One child in a pair shows emotion through facial expressions and body posture.
- The second child imitates his movements like a reflection in a mirror.
- After about a minute, ask students to switch roles.
- Finally, ask: "How can we tell what the other person is feeling?"

Exercise 19 – Where do we feel emotions?

 **Form of work:** individual / whole class  **Time:** 5 minutes

 Application usage: multimedia board / projector

Instructions:

- Display a card representing a chosen emotion. Ask students to consider what sensations might occur in their bodies when experiencing that emotion.
- Say:
- "Think about where in your body you might feel this emotion. You can point to that spot on your body."
- Ask students to point to selected areas, such as the stomach, heart, hands, face, or arms.

 **Tip:** Emphasize that everyone can experience emotions differently.

Exercise 20 – What could have happened?

 **Form of work:** group work / whole class  **Time:** 7 minutes

Instructions:

- Display a card depicting a person experiencing a specific emotion.
- Divide students into small groups and say, “Think about what might have happened before to make this person feel this way.”
- After a few minutes, ask the groups to present their ideas.

 **Hint:** Emphasize that we don't know the true story of the card's protagonist, and the answers presented are only possible explanations.

Exercise 21 – What can help?

 **Form of work:** whole class / individual

 **Time:** 5–7 minutes

Instructions:

- Display a card depicting a person experiencing a difficult emotion.

💬 Ask: "What would help this person feel better?"

- Write students' suggestions on the board.

💡 **Tip:** Encourage them to suggest different ways to cope with emotions, such as talking to a loved one, resting, breathing calmly, playing, moving, or drawing.

Exercise 22 – Question for the hero

👤 **Form of work:** individual / whole class

🕒 Time: 5 minutes

▶ **Instructions:**

- Display a card representing a person or situation.
- Say: "Imagine you could ask the character one question. What would you like to ask him?"
- Ask students to present their questions.
- 💡 **Tip:** Write down selected questions on the board and think about possible answers with your students.

Exercise 23 – My card for today

 **Form of work:** individual  **Time:** 5 minutes

 Instructions:

- Display several cards representing different emotions.
- Say: "Choose the card that best represents how you feel today."
- Ask students to point to the card they have chosen.
- Ask students who are willing to share why they chose a particular card.
- Conclude by saying, "Each of us may feel something different today. All emotions are important, and we can talk about them."

 **Tip:** This activity can be a starting point for students to create (draw/paint) their own card.

SCHOOLWELL is a set of emotion cards with exercises that supports the development of emotional and social competences of children and young people.

The set can be used with the whole class, in small groups, in pairs, or individually. Thanks to the variety of exercises, the cards can be adapted to the age, abilities, and current needs of students.

"Because well-being at school matters!"



**They develop
emotional
awareness**



**They strengthen
relationships and
empathy**



**They support
communication
and cooperation**

Included in the set:

- 22 picture cards,
- 18 question cards,
- exercises using cards,
- exercises using the SchoolWell app.

